

C O M M U N I C A T I O N S O P E R A T I O N A L
T O O L K I T

How to Communicate When the World Changes

Five operational tools for Communications Directors, PR teams, CCOs, and media relations managers. Designed for immediate use — scorecards to fill in, checklists to activate, scripts to read. Sources: PRSA, IABC, CIPR, documented corporate case studies.

5 tools

CCO · PR · Media Relations

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Toolkit contents:

- ▶ Tool 1 — Communications Readiness Scorecard (8 dimensions, fill-in)
- ▶ Tool 2 — Stakeholder Map & Cascade Checklist (priority order with timing)
- ▶ Tool 3 — Media Relations Guide (bridge statements, press templates, Q&A prep)
- ▶ Tool 4 — Digital & Social Media Protocol (trigger checklist, response macros)
- ▶ Tool 5 — Message Framework (how to communicate NHI disclosure in business language)

PRSA / IABC / CIPR documented principle applied throughout this toolkit:

Prepare in advance. Respond fast with a holding statement. Keep messages factual and empathetic. Coordinate internally before going external. Update continuously as facts change. Never speculate publicly on unverified information.

HOW TO USE THIS TOOLKIT

Three phases. Complete Tools 1 and 2 before any announcement. Activate Tools 3 and 4 at J0. Use Tool 5 whenever you need to communicate about the topic itself.

	PHASE 1 BEFORE J0	PHASE 2 J0 ANNOUNCEMENT	PHASE 3 J+1 to J+30
Tools:	Tool 1 — Scorecard Tool 2 — Cascade	Tool 3 — Media Tool 4 — Digital	Tool 5 — Messages All tools (review)

TOOL 1 — COMMUNICATIONS READINESS SCORECARD

PHASE 1 — Complete before any announcement. Owner: CCO or Communications Director.

 **Score each dimension 1 (unprepared) to 5 (fully ready). Fill "Today" column first. Run a tabletop drill, then score again in "After Drill." The gap shows where you are most vulnerable under pressure.**

Dimension	1	2	3	4	5	Priority action if score < 3
<i>1 = Unprepared 3 = Partial 5 = Fully Ready</i>						<i>Circle score → fill in action</i>
1. Crisis plan exists <i>Documented, tested, assigned owners</i>	1	2	3	4	5	
2. Holding statement ready <i>Pre-drafted template, legal sign-off obtained</i>	1	2	3	4	5	
3. Spokesperson trained <i>Bridging techniques practiced, media-trained</i>	1	2	3	4	5	
4. Stakeholder map complete <i>All audiences listed with contact and cascade order</i>	1	2	3	4	5	
5. Legal review path defined <i>Sign-off process documented, timing agreed</i>	1	2	3	4	5	
6. Digital monitoring active <i>Tools deployed, alerts configured, escalation defined</i>	1	2	3	4	5	
7. Internal channels ready <i>Single authoritative channel designated and tested</i>	1	2	3	4	5	
8. Message framework prepared <i>Core messages drafted for each scenario (A/B1/B2/C)</i>	1	2	3	4	5	

Score	Level	Action
8–16	HIGH RISK	Develop crisis plan this week. Draft holding statements. Brief legal on disclosure obligations.
17–26	PARTIAL	Focus on lowest-scored dimensions. Run a tabletop drill within 30 days.
27–32	GOOD	Update message frameworks for current signal level. Confirm legal sign-off path.
33–40	STRONG	Maintain quarterly drills. Ensure new team members are trained on the protocol.

TOOL 2 — STAKEHOLDER MAP & CASCADE CHECKLIST

PHASES 1 AND 2 — Map in advance. Activate at J0 in exact priority order.

SOURCE

PRSA, IABC, and CIPR documented principle: Internal audiences are briefed first because employees who receive information before the general public become advocates rather than sources of confusion. Never let your employees learn from the news.

Priority Cascade Order

#	Audience	What they need	Timing	Channel
1	Leadership, Legal, Comms	Full facts, decision authority, legal exposure analysis	H+0 to H+1	In-person / call
2	Communications team	Approved holding statement, spokesperson assignment, escalation rules	H+1	Briefing call
3	Employees (direct impact)	What we know, what we are doing, EAP/support available	H+2 to H+4	Manager + email
4	All employees	Official company statement, FAQ link, next update time	H+4	All-staff email + intranet
5	Regulators	Legally required disclosures. Coordinate with Legal before contact.	H+4 to H+12	Formal letter / call
6	Investors / IR	Material information via simultaneous public disclosure (Reg FD).	H+4 (simultaneous public)	Press release + 8-K if required
7	Customers / Partners	Service continuity, what this means for them, point of contact	H+8 to H+24	Email / portal
8	Media / Press	Holding statement only until full statement ready. No speculation.	H+4 (holding) H+24 (full)	Press release + spokesperson

ALERT

Reg FD critical point (IABC / SEC documented): Listed companies cannot privately brief investors before making information public. Material nonpublic information must be

disclosed simultaneously to all market participants. Prepare a public press release or 8-K to release at the same moment as any investor communication.

Stakeholder Map (fill in)

Stakeholder group	Key contact(s)	Priority / sensitivity	Preferred channel
Employees (direct)	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
All-staff	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
Board / C-suite	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
Legal / Compliance	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
Investors / IR	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
Key customers	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
Strategic partners	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
Regulators	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____
Media contacts	_____	High / Medium / Low	_____

TOOL 3 — MEDIA RELATIONS GUIDE

PHASES 2 AND 3 — Activate at J0. Spokesperson uses this guide directly.

SOURCE

PRSA documented principle: Anticipate the questions audiences will ask. Draft three key messages. Practice bridging until transitions are seamless. Never speculate publicly. Never say "no comment" — use a structured holding statement instead.

The Holding Statement — Structure and Template

 **Issue this within H+4. Do not wait for complete information. A holding statement is better than silence or "no comment."**

Element	What to include
Acknowledge	One sentence confirming you are aware of the situation. No speculation about cause or meaning.
Known facts only	State only what is confirmed. Two sentences maximum. Cite the source (official government announcement, etc.).
What you are doing	One sentence describing your response: "We have activated our crisis protocol / We are assessing the implications..."
What you do not know	Explicitly acknowledge uncertainty: "We do not yet have sufficient information to assess..." — this builds credibility.
Next update commitment	Give a specific time: "We will provide an update by [time]." Never leave media without a return time.
Contact	Name, email, and phone of your single designated media contact.

Holding Statement Template

"[Company name] is aware of [describe the official government/agency announcement in one factual sentence from confirmed public sources only]."

"We are actively assessing the potential implications for our organization and have activated our standard crisis protocol."

"At this time, we are not in a position to speculate on implications beyond what has been officially confirmed. We will share our assessment as soon as it is available."

"Our next communication will be issued by [specific time/date]."

Media enquiries: [Name, email, phone]

Bridge Statements — What to Say When You Do Not Know

Bridge statements allow spokespeople to answer questions without overclaiming. They redirect from speculation to facts. Practice these phrases until they are automatic. Source: PRSA and IABC crisis communication training materials.

Situation	Bridge statement
Asked about cause or meaning	<i>"What we can confirm right now is [X]. We are not yet in a position to assess the broader implications."</i>
Asked to speculate on scenarios	<i>"We are not ready to speculate. What we are doing is [specific action]. Our next update will be at [time]."</i>
Asked about financial / market impact	<i>"That assessment is ongoing. What I can tell you is that our business continuity protocol is activated and we are monitoring the situation closely."</i>
Asked about employee reactions	<i>"Our priority is ensuring our team has accurate information and support. We have activated our employee communication protocol."</i>
Asked "are you prepared for this?"	<i>"We have scenario planning processes in place for major unexpected events. This is one of those events, and we are following our protocol."</i>
Asked about competitors	<i>"I can only speak to our own organization's response. I would refer you to them directly."</i>
Facing repeated pressure	<i>"I understand you need more information. I am not going to speculate — I will give you our update at [time] as committed."</i>

Press Q&A Preparation — Anticipated Questions

 Pre-answer these questions before J0. Fill in your approved answer. Your spokesperson should be able to deliver each answer in under 30 seconds.

Anticipated press question	Pre-approved answer (fill in)
What is your reaction to this	

announcement?	
Does this affect your business operations?	
Are your employees concerned?	
What does this mean for your investors?	
Have you briefed your board?	
Do you have a continuity plan for this scenario?	
Will you be changing your strategy as a result?	

TOOL 4 — DIGITAL & SOCIAL MEDIA PROTOCOL

PHASE 2 AND 3 — Activate immediately at J0. Owner: Digital / Social Media Manager + Comms Director.

SOURCE

CIPR documented principle: Organizations should bridge traditional crisis management with digital channels. Use monitoring tools, proactive engagement, and preplanned responses to misinformation. Preplanned "dark site" content should be activatable within minutes, not hours.

Activation Checklist (do in order at J0)

Do ne	Owner	Action	By When
IMMEDIATE — WITHIN 30 MINUTES			
☐	Digital Lead	Pause all scheduled social media content. No pre-planned posts go live until situation is stabilized.	H+0
☐	Digital Lead	Activate social monitoring dashboard. Set alerts for company name, executives, and key topic terms.	H+0
☐	Digital Lead	Switch community management to high-alert mode. All public responses require supervisor approval.	H+1
☐	Comms Director	Activate "dark site" / crisis landing page. Confirm URL, loading, and contact form are live.	H+1
☐	IT / Comms	Designate one authoritative internal channel (e.g., #company-updates Slack / Teams). All other channels muted for crisis comms.	H+1
H + 1 TO H + 4 — CONTENT AND RESPONSE			
☐	Digital Lead	Publish first social media post (holding statement version). Consistent with press holding statement — not different.	H+4
☐	Digital Lead	Post pinned update on all active social channels. Link to crisis landing page.	H+4
☐	Internal Comms	Post first internal update on authoritative channel. Include: what we know, what we are doing, next update time.	H+2

☐	Digital Lead	Deploy approved response macros for incoming comments / DMs. Do not engage individually until approved.	H+4
☐	Digital Lead	Identify and log misinformation already circulating. Do not amplify by reacting without strategy.	H+4
H + 4 TO J + 7 — SUSTAINED MONITORING			
☐	Digital Lead	Hourly social sentiment check. Report to CCO. Escalate if volume spikes or misinformation spreads.	Hourly
☐	Internal Comms	Post timestamped updates on internal channel: "What changed since last update."	Every 4h
☐	Digital Lead	Update FAQ page as new questions come in. All answers legally cleared before posting.	Daily
☐	Comms Director	Review social tone daily. Adjust response macros if audience sentiment shifts.	Daily

Social Media Response Macros (pre-approved, fill in)

These are pre-drafted responses for the most common social media situations. Legal must clear them before J0. Never improvise on social media during a crisis.

Situation	Pre-approved response macro (fill in / adapt)
General concern or question about the announcement	<i>"Thank you for reaching out. We are actively monitoring the situation and will share updates on this page. Our next update: [time]."</i>
Request for company position	<i>"We have issued a statement which you can read at [URL]. We will not be speculating beyond confirmed facts."</i>
Misinformation about company involvement	<i>"This is inaccurate. [One sentence correction.] Please refer to our official statement at [URL]."</i>
Employee or customer expressing distress	<i>"We hear your concern. Our leadership team is actively addressing this. [If employee: our EAP is available at [number].]"</i>
Media request via social DM	<i>"Thank you for your inquiry. Please contact our media team directly at [email]. We aim to respond within [X hours]."</i>
Requests not to respond	<i>"We are monitoring all channels and taking all concerns seriously. We</i>

publicly	<i>will continue to update publicly as information is confirmed."</i>
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Monitoring KPIs — Track Daily

KPI	Type	Frequency	Alert threshold
Social mention volume	Leading	Hourly H+0 to H+24	> 3x baseline: escalate
Social sentiment score	Leading	Every 4h	Negative > 60%: escalate
Misinformation instances	Leading	Every 4h	Any viral misinformation: CCO alert
Press enquiry volume	Leading	Daily	> 10 enquiries/day: add spokesperson
Internal channel engagement	Leading	Daily	< 60% read rate: resend via alternative
FAQ page views	Lagging	Daily	Spike: update FAQ proactively
Media sentiment (press)	Lagging	Daily	Negative > 50%: revise messaging
Message consistency score	Lagging	Weekly	Deviation from approved messages: rebrief

TOOL 5 — MESSAGE FRAMEWORK

ALL PHASES — How to communicate NHI disclosure topics in credible business language.

LBDG

The unique LBDG challenge: Your organization needs to communicate about a topic that many people still consider fringe. This tool gives you the institutional grounding and the exact language to do it credibly without losing professional standing.

5.1 — The Institutional Validation Foundation

Before using any of the message frameworks below, your communications team needs to internalize these validated institutional signals. They are your credibility anchors.

Institution	What they said / did — and why it matters for your communications
Deloitte AG (2026)	Classified NHI disclosure as a credible Black Swan in their GPMESII Risk Intelligence Report — 2/5 probability within 5 years. When Deloitte puts something in a risk report, you can reference it in a board presentation without losing credibility.
Bank of England (analyst, Jan 2026)	Former senior analyst Helen McCaw publicly urged central banks to prepare for market instability from disclosure. A central bank analyst warning is the definition of institutional legitimacy.
Tuttle Capital / CBOE (Feb 2026)	UFOD ETF launched on a major exchange — the first investment fund explicitly pricing disclosure risk. Financial markets are pricing this. If markets price it, your finance team can discuss it.
U.S. DoD / Pentagon (ongoing)	AARO confirmed, 2,000+ cases. PURSUE declassification live at war.gov/ufo. Presidential executive order issued. This is official government action, not speculation.
Col. Karl Nell (US Army ret.)	Former Army intelligence officer and UAP Task Force liaison presented a formal disclosure framework at Stanford University. Military + academic = maximum institutional credibility.

5.2 — What to Say and Not Say

The core principle from PRSA and CIPR crisis communications: stick to observable facts, acknowledge uncertainty, and avoid rhetorical overreach. Applied here:

DO NOT say	SAY THIS INSTEAD
"We are preparing for alien contact."	"We are conducting Black Swan scenario

	planning consistent with guidance from Deloitte AG's 2026 Risk Intelligence Report."
<i>"UFOs are real and we need to get ready."</i>	"Recent declassifications and institutional signals indicate a major paradigm-shifting announcement may occur. We are preparing accordingly."
<i>"The government is hiding aliens."</i>	"The U.S. Department of Defense has released over 160 classified files under the PURSUE program. We are monitoring official developments."
<i>"This could destroy the energy sector."</i>	"Our sector exposure analysis identifies potential long-term implications for conventional energy, consistent with a 15-30 year structural transition scenario."
<i>"Nobody is taking this seriously."</i>	"Deloitte AG, the Bank of England, and institutional investors on CBOE are among the organizations that have flagged this as a credible risk."
<i>"We might go bankrupt if this happens."</i>	"We have completed a reverse stress test to identify our resilience thresholds under major paradigm-shifting scenarios."

5.3 — Core Message Framework by Scenario

Prepare these messages before J0. Legal must clear them. Each scenario (A, B1, B2, C) has a different risk level and therefore different messaging. Do not use Scenario C language for a Scenario A event.

Scenario	What has happened	Core message (adapt to your organization)
A Soft	Government acknowledges UAP / NHI existence. No technology or contact confirmed.	<i>"We are aware of the official announcement. This is a matter we have been monitoring as part of our Black Swan preparedness framework. Our operations are unaffected. We are assessing potential second-order implications and will update stakeholders as our analysis develops."</i>
B1 Retrieval	Crash retrieval programs confirmed. No commercializable technology. No reverse engineering announced.	<i>"We have reviewed the official disclosure. The institutional implications are significant, particularly for defense and security sectors. Our organization has no direct exposure to the confirmed programs. We are monitoring developments and will brief our board within 48 hours."</i>

B2 Partial RE	Partial reverse engineering confirmed. Technology managed as national security asset — not commercialized.	<i>"We note the significant implications of this disclosure for certain sectors. Our sector exposure analysis, updated in line with this announcement, has been reviewed by our board. We are applying our standard crisis governance protocol. Our financial position remains [stable / to be assessed]."</i>
C Contact	Full confirmation of ongoing non-human intelligence contact.	<i>"We are operating under our crisis governance protocol. Leadership is convened continuously. The welfare of our people is our first priority. We are not in a position to assess the full implications of this announcement at this time. We will communicate with all stakeholders on a confirmed schedule. Our next update: [time]."</i>

5.4 — The Business Language Glossary

Use these terms consistently in all external communications. They frame the topic in the language institutional audiences understand and respect.

Instead of...	Use...
<i>"UFOs" / "aliens"</i>	"Non-human intelligence (NHI)" / "unidentified aerial phenomena (UAP)" — the official government terminology
<i>"Preparing for disclosure"</i>	"Black Swan scenario planning" / "paradigm-shifting event preparedness"
<i>"Something strange happened"</i>	"An institutional disclosure event has occurred"
<i>"We don't know what to do"</i>	"We are operating under our standard crisis governance protocol"
<i>"This could be huge"</i>	"The second-order implications are being assessed in accordance with our risk management framework"
<i>"Everyone is panicking"</i>	"We are monitoring stakeholder sentiment and deploying our employee support resources"
<i>"The economy might collapse"</i>	"Our stress test scenarios include paradigm-shifting macro events — we have pre-defined thresholds and response actions"

SOURCES

Source	Application in this toolkit
PRSA — Public Relations Society of America	Crisis communication structure, spokesperson training, media handling best practices (Tools 1, 2, 3)
IABC — International Association of Business Communicators	H+1/H+4/H+24 timing model, stakeholder cascade framework, reputation recovery (Tools 1, 2, 3)
CIPR — Chartered Institute of Public Relations (UK)	Social media crisis management, internal communications priority, dark site protocols (Tools 4)
SEC Regulation FD	Selective disclosure rules applied to stakeholder cascade order and investor communication (Tool 2)
Deloitte AG (2026)	NHI disclosure as credible Black Swan — institutional validation anchor (Tool 5)
Bank of England analyst (McCaw, 2026)	Central bank preparedness warning — financial credibility anchor (Tool 5)
Col. Karl Nell (US Army ret., 2023)	Controlled vs catastrophic disclosure framework — scenario framework (Tool 5)
DoD / AARO / PURSUE (2022-2026)	Official government UAP program references — factual grounding for all message frameworks (Tool 5)

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